



Food Waste

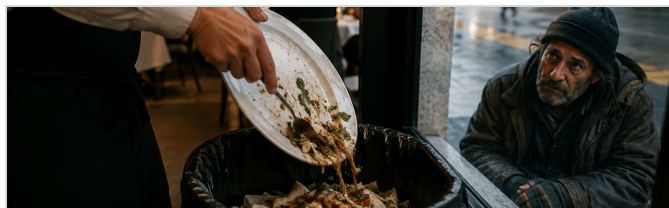
Whose problem is it, really?

We are told to clean our plates. The biggest losses happen long before food reaches them.



Listen to the article

Scan the QR code or visit the link.



Perfectly good food is discarded daily while millions still experience hunger worldwide.

WARM-UP

Discuss the questions with a partner.

1. When you throw food away, do you feel guilty, indifferent, or annoyed at whoever sold it to you?
2. Is wasting food morally different from wasting money or energy? Why might it feel different?

Somewhere in a supermarket's back room, a pallet of yogurt is being tipped into a dumpster. Nothing is wrong with it; it simply reaches its "best before" date tomorrow, and tomorrow the shelf belongs to a fresher batch. Scenes like this rarely make the news. Instead, the public conversation about food waste tends to settle on our own fridges: the forgotten lettuce, the leftovers kept too long. It is a story that places the blame close to home, and perhaps conveniently so.

Roughly a third of the world's food is never eaten, and the losses occur at every stage. In poorer countries, much of it spoils before it reaches market, for lack of cold storage or decent roads. In wealthier ones, waste gathers at the end of the chain. Households do waste a great deal, but within a system that quietly encourages it: multi-buy offers, oversized portions, and date labels that many shoppers misread, preferring to **err on the side of caution** and bin food that is perfectly safe.

Much of the waste consumers never see. Farmers plow under crops too crooked or too small for supermarket specifications, and retailers can cancel orders at short notice when demand dips. Critics say the industry has long been content to **turn a blind eye** to these losses, since the cost is absorbed further down the line. Rotting in landfills, it releases methane, making waste a climate problem as well as a moral one.

Some governments now **hold** retailers **accountable**: France requires large supermarkets to donate unsold edible food rather than destroy it. Yet donation has limits: charities cannot absorb it all, and giving surplus away does not stop it being produced. Others insist individual effort matters, even if one household's savings are **a drop in the ocean**. The risk is that each side simply **shifts the blame** onto the other.

If everyone is partly responsible, is anyone truly accountable?

VOCABULARY

A. Match the expressions (1–5) with their meanings (A–E).

- | | |
|------------------------------------|---------------------------------|
| 1. shift the blame ____ | A. to ignore on purpose |
| 2. err on the side of caution ____ | B. to blame someone else |
| 3. turn a blind eye to ____ | C. to make answerable |
| 4. a drop in the ocean ____ | D. to play it safe |
| 5. hold (sb) accountable ____ | E. too small to matter |

TRUE OR FALSE

Judge what the article states *or implies*. Circle T or F.

- | | | |
|--|----------|----------|
| 1. Poor nations waste most food at home. | T | F |
| 2. The writer doubts the household focus. | T | F |
| 3. Donation laws fully solve the problem. | T | F |
| 4. Date labels can mislead shoppers. | T | F |
| 5. The writer dismisses individual effort. | T | F |

DISCUSSION

- 1 What food do you throw away most often, and whose decision really caused it?
- 2 Should supermarkets be allowed to reject food purely because of how it looks?
- 3 Why might it suit retailers for the public to focus on household waste?
- 4 If your effort is only a drop in the ocean, is it still an obligation?
- 5 Should wasting edible food ever be illegal? For whom, and why?



01 CRITICAL THINKING

WHERE DOES THE BLAME LAND?

Days before harvest, a supermarket cancels an order. Twenty tonnes of edible carrots are plowed back into the soil.

Judge each defense first. Then divide 10 points of responsibility among the five. Your points must add up to 10.

WHO	THEIR DEFENSE	DOES IT HOLD?	SHARE
The farmer	"I grew exactly what was ordered, and I can't store it."	Yes Partly No	___/10
The supermarket	"Shoppers won't buy crooked carrots. We sell what they choose."	Yes Partly No	___/10
The shoppers	"We only pick what looks best. Nobody asked us."	Yes Partly No	___/10
The government	"It's a private contract. We can't run every business."	Yes Partly No	___/10
The food bank	"We can't collect and store twenty tonnes at two days' notice."	Yes Partly No	___/10

YOUR VERDICT Largest share: _____ The defense your group found hardest to reject: _____

- DISCUSS**
- 1 Did anyone score zero? What would it take to justify that?
 - 2 Compare with another group. Challenge the actor they let off most lightly.
 - 3 Is being responsible the same as being able to fix it? Who could fix this most cheaply?

02 LANGUAGE IN CONTEXT

USE THE LANGUAGE

Complete each sentence with an expression from the box.
Change the form if you need to.

a drop in the ocean hold accountable
shift the blame turn a blind eye to
err on the side of caution

- 1 Managers often _____ onto junior staff.
- 2 When in doubt, I _____ and throw it out.
- 3 For years, inspectors _____ the waste.
- 4 One family's savings are just _____
- 5 Retailers must be _____ for what they discard.

04 WRITING

YOUR OPINION

"Food waste is a failure of systems, not of individuals." To what extent do you agree?

Write 200–250 words. Address the strongest opposing view before you answer it.

03 SPEAKING CHALLENGE

ROLE • PROPOSE • DEFEND

In small groups, build one position and hold it under pressure.

ROLE You are a minister asked to cut national food waste in half.

PROPOSE Choose ONE measure. Say which group will pay most for it, and why that is fair.

DEFEND Present in two minutes. A group speaking for that sector then opposes you. Answer them without abandoning your measure.